CHAPTER 1

Posture & Hand Shape



Sit tall, like a puppet on a string

Before the first note: how to sit, and how to hold your hands. Get these right, and every note after them is easier.

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By the end, you can

- [ ] sit at the right height and distance
- [ ] move your hand with the whole arm
- [ ] make a round hand and play on the tips
- [ ] say every finger number, on both hands

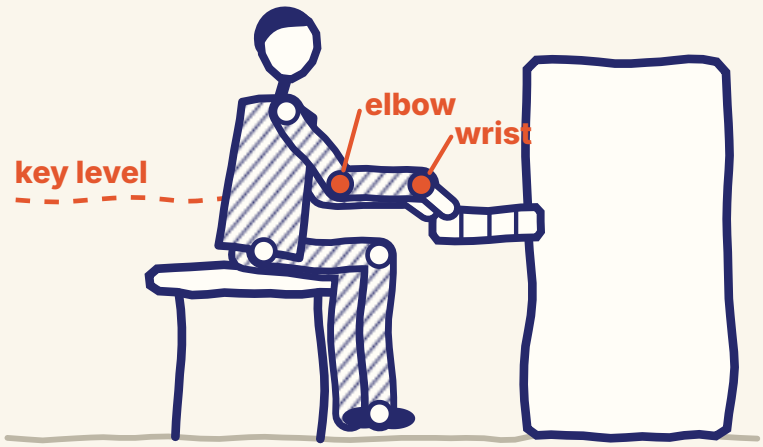
Goes with: the Workbook page beside each lesson page, and the online lesson (scan the code below).

TEACHER This chapter is the base for every other one. The five checks on page 7 come before every time at the piano, for every student at every level, not only for beginners.

Try it in the app

Step 1

Sit at the piano

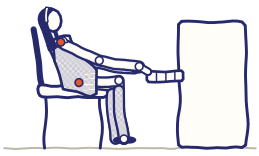


Two things to set: **how high** and **how far**. Your forearm is level with the keys, and your elbows sit just in front of your body.

At the piano

1. Sit on the **front half of the stool**, feet flat on the floor, leaning a little toward the piano. ☐
2. Raise or lower the stool until your **forearm is level** with the keys. ☐
3. Slide in or out until your **elbows are just in front of you**, about a fist away from your sides. ☐

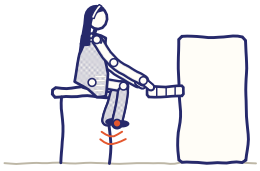
Not like this



× Leaning back, like on a sofa



× So close the elbows squash in



× Too high: feet swinging

REMEMBER **Front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall, leaning a little forward.**

TEACHER Watch for elbows squashed in (too close) or arms reaching out (too far). Feet dangling? A footstool or a sturdy box fixes it. Say: "Sit tall, like a puppet on a string."

Step 2

Let the arm carry the hand

Your fingertips stay connected to the piano, but the **whole arm** does the work: from above, it leads the hand and the fingers. Six moves, **in this order**, from the big parts of the body to the small ones: each one gets the arm ready for the next.



1 Rag doll

Flop forward and let both arms hang heavy. Shake them loose, then float the hands up and set them gently on the keys.



2 Elbow wings

Check the elbows are free, not stuck to your body: let them float out like wings, then back. Stop in the middle, a fist from your body.



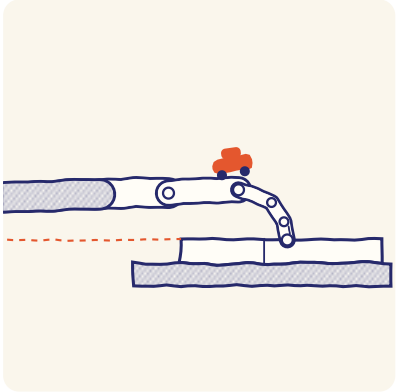
3 Arm glide

Now the whole arm: skate along the keys. The round hand rides on the arm to the next group of keys. The fingers ride, they don't walk.



4 Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 Knuckle bridge

Check the bridge: your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3: the bridge stays up.



6 Wrist balloon

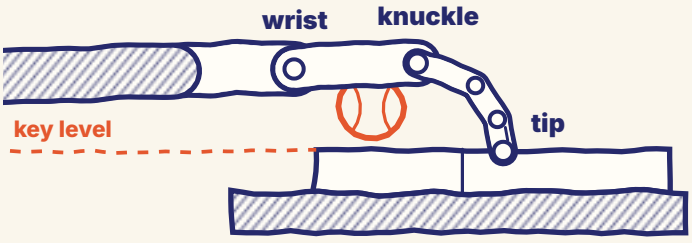
Check the wrist never sinks: as the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist straight back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

REMEMBER **The arm leads from above, elbows free. Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free.**

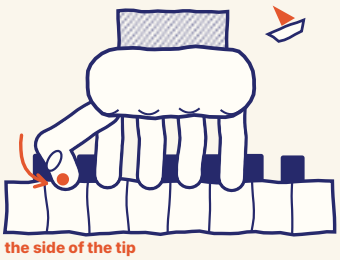
TEACHER Do all six in this order: each one checks something the next one needs. After every key, watch the wrist: it comes straight back up to level and never sinks. Say: "Arms heavy, like wet spaghetti. Now rest them on the keys."

Step 3

A round hand



Round, like holding a ball



The thumb bends in and plays on the side of its tip, like a tipped boat

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if you were holding a small ball. Keep that shape when the hand goes on the keys. **Knuckles up** like a bridge, and play on the **fingertips**. The wrist stays free: with the fingertip on the key, the hand can sway up and down and side to side, as if a **roller** sat under your forearm.

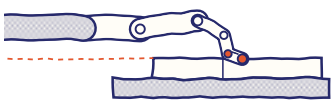
At the piano

1. Hands on your knees. Hold an imaginary ball. ☐
2. Move the ball shape onto the keys without squashing it. ☐
3. Play one key with each finger, on the tip. The knuckles stay up. ☐
4. Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side, as if on a roller. Notice the knuckles and the tip, and try not to let them cave in. ☐

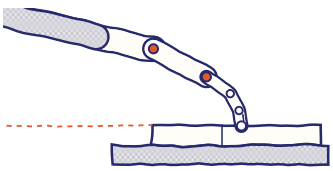
Not like this



× Flat fingers



× Tip joint caving in



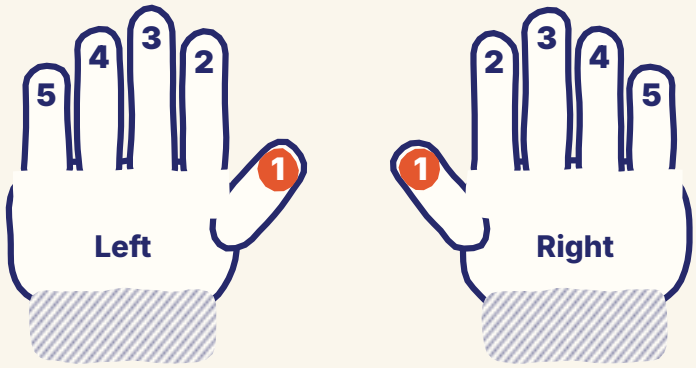
× Wrist stiff and high

REMEMBER **A free wrist, as if on a roller. Keep an eye on the knuckles and fingertips.**

TEACHER Watch the tip joint, especially on finger 5: for now, just help the student notice it. Say: "Hold a little bubble in your hand. Don't pop it!"

Step 4

Finger numbers



Every finger has a number, **1 to 5, starting from the thumb**. It's the same on both hands: both thumbs are 1, and both little fingers are 5.

1 Captain Thumb · **2 Pointer** · **3 Tall Middle** · **4 Shy Ring** · **5 Baby Pinky**

The mirror game

1. Hold both hands up. Wiggle each finger as you say its number. ☐
2. Your teacher calls "Right hand, 3!" and you wiggle it. Try ten calls. ☐
3. Swap: you call the finger, and your teacher wiggles it. ☐



REMEMBER **Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.**

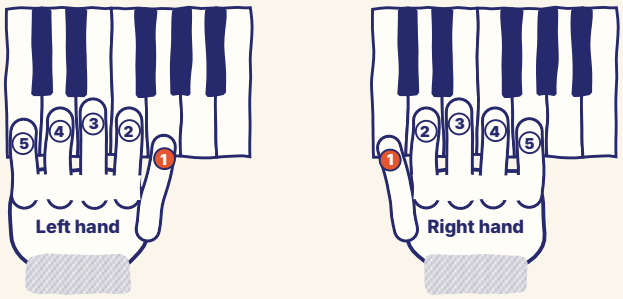
TEACHER Watch for the left hand numbered from the little finger. Say: "Thumbs are always 1. Your hands are mirror twins."

Try it in the app

Play

Finger walks

Now put it together: sit well, make a round hand, and play. **Start small:** one note, then two, three, four, and all five. From key to key, the hand draws a little **rainbow**: relaxed, never squeezed tight, the whole hand helping. **One circle is one steady beat.**





Hop on 3

one note: an arm drop on every 3

3 ○ 3 ○ | 3 3 3 ○



Neighbours

two notes, next door, taking turns

2 3 2 3 | 3 2 3 ○



Up and back

three notes: up, then back down

1 2 3 ○ | 3 2 1 ○



Little hill

four notes: up the hill and down

1 2 3 4 | 3 2 1 ○



Stairs and slide

all five: up the stairs, then down the slide

1 2 3 4 5 ○ | 5 4 3 2 1 ○

An empty dashed circle means: hold the note for one more beat.



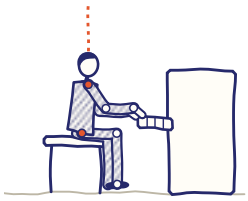
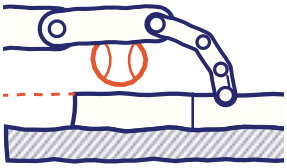
REMEMBER **A little rainbow from key to key. Relaxed: the whole hand helps.**

TEACHER Right hand first, then left hand, then together if it is easy. Move on to the next tune only when the hand stays round. Any five white keys near the middle will do; your teacher shows where to put the hand, and the letter names come in chapter 3.

Step 5

My five checks

Before you play, every time. Give yourself a star for each check in each lesson.

	Lesson 1	2	3	4	5	6
 **Front half of the stool**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Sit tall, like a puppet on a string**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Forearm level with the keys, elbows away from your body**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Round hand, play on the tips**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



REMEMBER **Check your posture before every practice.**

TEACHER At the start of each lesson, the student says the five checks out loud while doing them; you only correct. When all five are easy, do the Chapter check-up in the Workbook.